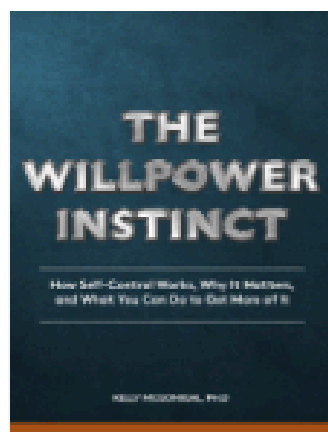




THE WILLPOWER INSTINCT

How Self-Control Works, Why It Matters,
and What You Can Do to Get More of It

KELLY MCGONIGAL, PH.D



The Big “So What”

All of us missed goals at some point because we gave in to distractions or temptations, or failed to do what we should. Willpower failures are *not* a sign of personal weakness, but the result of several physical, mental-emotional and social factors. **This book explains willpower using insights from economics, psychology, neuroscience, and medicine, with a range of tips and strategies to help you overcome distraction, temptation and procrastination.**



Introduction



Willpower is the ability to exercise self-control when you need it. To improve your self-control, you must understand why you lose control and what you can do about it. This book is based on the popular course “The Science of Willpower” by Stanford University psychologist and educator Kelly McGonigal. The book mirrors her 10-week course, with each chapter covering (i) a key scientific insight and (ii) practical exercises/strategies to help you develop self-awareness and address real-life challenges.



McGonigal recommends that you approach the ideas like a scientist.

Willpower Exercise: Choose a *willpower challenge* you've been trying to overcome. Then, try out each of the strategies below. Collect data and figure out what works (or doesn't work) for you.

KEY QUOTES

“Most people feel like willpower failures—in control one moment but overwhelmed and out of control the next.”

“Self-knowledge—especially of how we find ourselves in willpower trouble—is the foundation of self-control.”

“You can—and should—make yourself the subject of your own real-world study.”



Understand and Improve your Self-Control



What Is Willpower and Why It Matters



Willpower is much more than the ability to say “no” to temptation. It comprises 3 powers to help you become better:

- “I will” power: Doing things that improve your quality of life;
- “I won’t” power: Not doing things that impairs your happiness, well-being or success; and
- “I want” power: Focusing on your most important long-term goal.

In short, **self-control is about finding your motivation at the right time**. It’s about remembering what you truly want so you can do what you should and resist what you shouldn’t.



Willpower matters. All of us have the capacity for self-control, but how far you use it determines your physical health, financial stability, academic and professional success, quality of relationships, and levels of stress and happiness.



Willpower Is Affected By Your Brain



We struggle with self-control because we literally have multiple minds, each with conflicting thoughts, feelings, and goals.

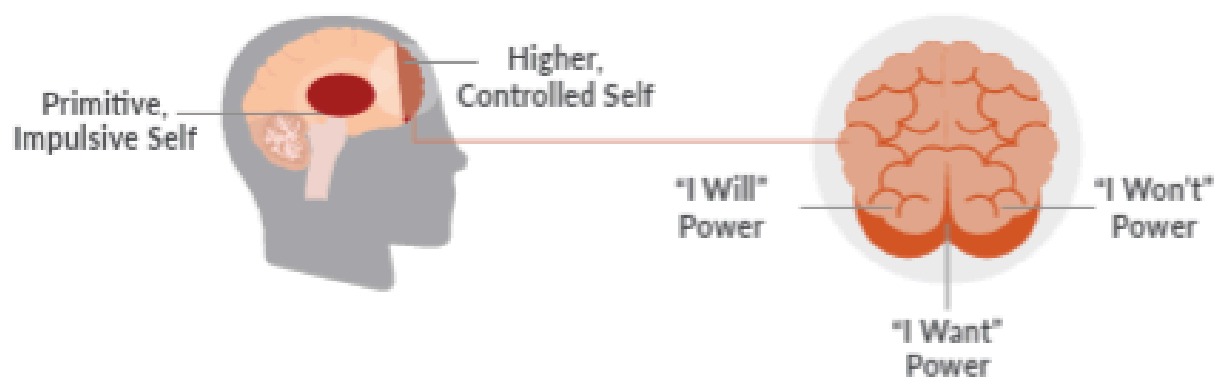
- The prefrontal cortex in our brain controls logical thinking and what we focus on. It has 3 different regions:
 - (i) The *left side* helps you to start and persist in tasks (“I will”).
 - (ii) The *right side* helps you to resist acting on every impulse (“I won’t”).
 - (iii) The *lower-middle area* helps you to track your goals and desires (“I want”). When these cells are firing rapidly, you’re more motivated to take action or resist temptation.

KEY QUOTES

“Willpower is actually three powers...that help us to be a better version of ourselves.”

“People who have better control of their attention, emotions, and actions are better off almost any way you look at it.”

“When it comes to self-control, we’ve seen that the human mind is not one unified self, but multiple selves who compete for control.”



- The prefrontal cortex is built on top of the more primal part of our brain that acts on urges and instincts. These impulses evolved to help us survive, e.g. we prefer sweet and fatty foods because they give us energy, and our feelings (e.g. fear or disgust) stop us from doing things to hurt or isolate ourselves.
- In short, part of our brain seeks to feel good *now*, while another part manages the impulses so we can achieve *long-term goals*. The 2 minds are in a constant battle. We want a slim body but we also want to enjoy a cookie. We want to excel in our exams and but we also want to watch TV.
- When we're drunk, exhausted or distracted, the prefrontal cortex loses part of its capabilities, making it harder for us to exert self-control. Students trying to remember a telephone number are 50% more likely to choose chocolate cake over fruit, and distracted shoppers are more likely to buy promotional items that aren't on their shopping lists.

Willpower Exercise: Consider what makes your willpower challenge difficult. What do you feel when you think about it?



To strengthen your willpower, you need to develop self-awareness. Understand your impulses and recognize when you must exercise self-control, so you can activate your prefrontal cortex to make conscious choices instead of defaulting to the easiest option.

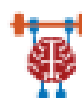
Willpower Exercises:

- What do your 2 selves (impulsive vs wise selves) want to do?
- *Track your choices.* At least once per day, consider the choices you've made. Which choices support or undermine your goal? What was happening when you made those choices (e.g. were you distracted or tired)?

KEY QUOTES

"While we all have the capacity to do the harder thing, we also have the desire to do exactly the opposite."

"While we're stuck with the impulse, we're also equipped with the impulse control."

 The more you exercise your prefrontal cortex, the bigger, faster and stronger it gets (just like how physical muscles are built). Meditation increases blood flow to the prefrontal cortex to improve your focus and self-control.

Willpower Exercise: Do 5 mins of brain-training meditation daily. Sit still and focus on your breath. Think “inhale” and “exhale” as you breathe. Notice when your mind wanders, and just refocus on your breathing. Don’t fidget! You’re training yourself not to act on every impulse, to activate your prefrontal cortex and quieten the stress/craving centers.



Willpower Is Affected By Your Body

 Scientists have found that self-control is more about physiology than psychology. This means that **you can train yourself to get into an ideal physiological state for self-control.**

- When you’re facing a real external threat (e.g. a robber in an alley), the primal brain triggers the fight-or-flight response. Your prefrontal cortex is inhibited so you can act without overthinking, your body releases hormones to unlock energy and your heart pumps harder to send blood and oxygen throughout the body to help you survive.
- When you’re facing a temptation (e.g. a delicious cheesecake), your body also reacts physically. Your attention is focused on the cake, your heart rate increases and your blood sugar level falls as your body anticipates the sugar rush. However, once you realize that you’re dealing with an internal conflict (not a real threat), you can calm the brain/body and dampen the impulses.

Willpower Exercise: Name the impulse that you must control to succeed in your willpower challenge (e.g. the “cookie monster” that can’t resist cookies, or “the critic” who keeps complaining).

 Psychologist Suzanne Segerstrom found that self-control comes with an opposite physiological state from stress. She calls this the pause-and-plan response.

KEY QUOTES

“Willpower is a biological instinct, like stress, that evolved to help us protect ourselves from ourselves.”

“The perception of an internal conflict triggers changes in the brain and body that help you slow down and control your impulses.”

“Like the fight-or-flight response, the pause-and-plan response begins in the brain.”

- Pause-and-plan is about slowing down so your prefrontal cortex can step in to calm your breathing/heart rate, relax your muscles, and redirect energy to the brain. This allows you to think clearly and calmly, refocus on your long-term goals and explore options instead of acting on impulse.
- Your heart rate variability is one of the best indicators of how stressed or calm you are.
 - (i) Under normal circumstances, your heart rate varies naturally, e.g. it increases slightly when you inhale and decreases when you exhale. When you're stressed, your heart rate goes up and stays up (i.e. variability decreases).
 - (ii) People with higher heart rate variability are more likely to delay gratification, resist distractions, persevere in face of difficulty or failure, and cope with stressful situations.
- To exert self-control, first calm your body, decrease your heart rate and increase its variability.

Willpower Exercise: Before facing a willpower challenge, *slow down your breathing* to just 4-5 breaths per minute (or 10-15s per breath). Do this for 1-2 minutes to activate your prefrontal cortex, increase your heart rate variability and put yourself in a physiological state of self-control.

-  Basically, anything that reduces stress also improves your willpower reserve. This includes exercise, adequate sleep, a sound diet, quality time with family/friends, and spiritual practices.

Willpower Exercise: Observe what happens when you're stressed. Are you more likely to lose self-control or procrastinate?

- There's now extensive research to show that exercise helps to increase focus and self-control in all aspects of life. Participants in a study had less cravings after just 15 min on the treadmill. In the long-term, exercise also increases baseline heart rate variability and the growth of gray/white matter in the brain to make your brain bigger and faster.

"Stress is the enemy of willpower."

"Exercise turns out to be the closest thing to a wonder drug that self-control scientists have discovered."

Willpower Exercise: Do 5min of green exercise, i.e. physical activity done outdoors in nature. Or, opt for any non-sedentary activity that you enjoy, e.g. walking, gardening, dancing.

- Sleep deprivation makes you more vulnerable to stress and temptations. When you're tired, your cells can't absorb glucose as effectively and become under-fueled. A lack of sleep (<6 hours a night) impairs your prefrontal cortex to reduce focus and self-control. Prolonged lack of sleep also increases your stress hormones and decreases heart rate variability.

Willpower Exercise: Aim for 8hrs of uninterrupted sleep every night, or minimally take a short nap daily.

- Choose your willpower challenges carefully. Don't try to control everything, or you'll run out of energy/focus and feel chronically stressed.

Willpower Exercise: Restore your willpower reserve by taking a few minutes to *relax*. Lie down and breathe deeply for 5-10 min to give your brain/body a complete break.



Willpower Works Like Muscles



Our willpower follows the same use-it-or-lose-it rule as physical muscles. It becomes weak with neglect, can get exhausted from non-stop use, but can also be strengthened with proper training. Learn to pace yourself: alternate between pushing your limits and recovery.



Once you exhaust your limited willpower reserves, you become more susceptible to temptations and bad decisions. Smokers who don't smoke for 24 hours are more likely to binge on ice cream, and people who diet are more likely to cheat on their spouses.

- Our self-control is the highest in the morning and gradually depletes throughout the day with every conscious choice and activity we undertake. Aim to:

KEY QUOTES

"To preserve both your health and happiness...you will have to choose your willpower battles wisely."

"Self-control is like a muscle. It gets tired from use, but regular exercise makes it stronger."

"We cannot control everything, and yet the only way to increase our self-control is to stretch our limits."

- (i) Start the day with the hardest or most important challenge;
- (ii) Periodically replenish your willpower reserves; and
- (iii) Build your overall willpower capacity.

Willpower Exercise: Observe how your willpower levels fluctuate throughout the day and week. Plan your schedule to avoid temptations when your self-control is at its weakest.

- Self-control requires energy. Participants in a study were given a series of self-control tasks. Those who received a sugared drink to restore blood sugar showed improved self-control compared to those who received a drink with artificial sweeteners. The absolute blood sugar level isn't as vital as the direction of change—when the brain detects a drop in blood sugar, it starts to conserve energy, leaving less mental resources for self-control.

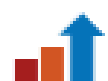
Willpower Exercise: Maintain your blood sugar level with a low-glycemic diet (e.g. lean proteins, nuts/beans, high-fiber grains/cereals, fruits and vegetables).



During endurance sports, you start to feel tired before your body is truly fatigued. Athletes routinely push past this initial fatigue to perform closer to their real physical limits. Likewise, our brain starts to conserve mental energy *before* our willpower reserves are truly depleted. You can transcend your initial mental exhaustion with the right motivation:

- Students who were too tired to finish their tasks suddenly had the will to do so when they were given new incentives.
- A young woman couldn't stop shouting at her kids even though she tried to be a good mother. Once she realized that her true motivation was to enjoy parenthood (not to be a model mum), she was able to change how she engaged her kids.

Willpower Exercise: Find your biggest want and use it as a source of motivation whenever you need a willpower boost.



Build your self-control muscles like how athletes build muscles:

KEY QUOTES

"If we want to strengthen self-control, we may need to think about how we can best support the most exhausted version of ourselves—and not count on an ideal version of ourselves to show up and save the day."

*"Fatigue should no longer be considered a physical event but rather a sensation or emotion."
—Timothy Noakes*

"Sometimes our strongest motivation is not what we think it is, or think it should be."

"When there's a want, there's a will."

- Control 1 small thing that you don't normally control.

Willpower Exercise: *Flex your self-control muscle:*

- I Won't: Stop doing something you usually do, e.g. refrain from swearing or using your dominant hand.
- I Will: Do something daily that you don't normally do, e.g. helping someone, meditating for 5 minutes.
- Self-Monitoring: Track something you don't usually pay attention to, e.g. daily expenses, time usage.

- Routinely push your limits:

Willpower Exercise: The next time you feel too tired for self-control, just push yourself 1 step beyond the point of fatigue.



Moral Licensing Can Cause Self-Sabotage



We tend to moralize willpower, i.e. we think we're "good" if we succeed at a willpower challenge and "bad" if we fail. This triggers mental traps which increase the risks of self-sabotage.



When we think we're "good", we trust our impulses (including the bad ones) or tell ourselves that we deserve a treat. So, the more we do something "good" or moral, the more we may do something "bad" or immoral later. Psychologists call this moral licensing.

- Thinking of past or potential virtues can lead to less virtuous behavior. When people were asked to recall a time they acted generously, they gave 60% less to a charitable request compared to a control group. Even when people were asked to consider donating money to charity (without actually donating it), they became more likely to treat themselves later.

Willpower Exercise: Do you associate your willpower struggles with morality? Do you indulge after being "good" and does it jeopardize your goal?

KEY QUOTES

"We can...push past the feeling of willpower exhaustion to make it to the finish line of our own willpower challenges."

"Whenever we have conflicting desires, being good gives us permission to be a little bit bad."

KEY QUOTES

- Moral licensing increases when people pay a penance for bad behavior which erases their guilt. For example, people who pay to plant a tree may feel justified to use even more electricity. It's better to get people to engage in good behaviors that replace the bad ones (e.g. paying 10% more for green energy), since it reinforces their identity (e.g. "I'm someone who cares about the environment") to increase their commitment.

Willpower Exercise: Do you identify more with your long-term goals or with your short-term impulses?

- Stop moralizing willpower struggles. Robbing a bank or physically hurting someone may be a moral breach, but missing a session at the gym isn't.



We may feel so good about making progress that we reward ourselves with an indulgence that jeopardizes our goal.

- The solution is to focus on your goal, not the progress you've made. When students were asked to recall how they rejected a temptation in the past, they indulged themselves at the next available opportunity. However, the moral licensing effect was negated when they recalled the incident and why they'd resisted the temptation. By remembering your "why", you'll realize that the indulgence is not a reward but a threat to your goal.

Willpower Exercise: The next time you use progress to justify indulgence, stop and remember your "why".



The halo effect kicks in when the good feelings from 1 thing affects how we see other things. It may create the illusion that a "good" choice will cancel out a "bad" one. People who eat a salad and a burger think they're consuming fewer calories than those who're eating just a burger. Bargain-hunters may feel so good about saving money that they buy more than intended.

Willpower Exercises:

- Watch for halo effects, e.g. when you justify a vice due to a virtuous trait like "buy 1 get 1 free" or "organic".
- Use a concrete counter-measure (e.g. calories consumed, total cost, time spent) to weigh the net impact.

"Moralizing a behavior makes us more, not less, likely to feel ambivalent about it."

"For better self-control, forget virtue, and focus on goals and values."

"When we want permission to indulge, we'll take any hint of virtue as a justification to give in."

 We're overly optimistic about our ability to do the right thing in the future, e.g. we overeat now on the promise that we'll exercise later.

- Counter this by assuming that tomorrow will be just like today (not better). Instead of asking "Should I have this ice-cream now?" ask "Do I want to face the consequences of eating an ice-cream every day?"

Willpower Exercises:

- Do you promise to take action tomorrow to make up for today's indulgence? Do you actually follow through?
- Assume that tomorrow will be like today, and your current choice will reflect *all* future choices.



We Confuse Desire with Happiness

 When our brain recognizes an opportunity for reward it releases dopamine, a neurotransmitter that focuses our attention on the potential source of reward. It concurrently releases stress hormones so we feel stressed about not having that item yet.

- A dopamine rush fills us with anticipation of a reward. We don't feel happy or satisfied because it doesn't actually deliver on the promise. Yet we're afraid to stop in case we lose out.
 - (i) When lab rats were given access to levers that triggered brain stimulation, they ignored food and burned their feet just to keep pressing the levers. Human patients who were given a control box to stimulate their brains got so addicted that they refused to stop and eat even when they were hungry.
 - (ii) We keep playing video games to get to the next victory/level. Gamblers keep betting in hopes of the next big win. Surrounded by temptations, we can feel constantly-wanting yet never-satisfied.
- Dopamine makes you susceptible to all sorts of temptation.
 - (i) Parkinson's disease is often treated with drugs that flood the patients' system with dopamine. This eases the

KEY QUOTES

"We wrongly but persistently expect to make different decisions tomorrow than we do today."

"Dopamine is for action, not happiness...[it brings] anticipation, not pleasure."

"Our brains mistake the promise of reward for a guarantee of happiness, so we chase satisfaction from things that do not deliver."

symptoms but creates side effects e.g. binge-eating, gambling, alcoholism or excessive sexual urges.

- (ii) Shoppers who're given free samples of something sweet are more likely to buy indulgent foods or sale items, and scent marketers use smells to trigger dopamine release. Sexy models are used to promote all sorts of items.

Willpower Exercises:

- Observe your inner dopamine triggers, and how retailers and marketers lure you with the promise of reward.
- When you give in to temptation, do you feel happier or more anxious?

 It's impossible to restrict/ban dopamine stimulants. However, you can reduce their impact just by being aware of their true nature.

- Learn to differentiate between real vs false rewards. Real rewards give you meaning and satisfaction, while false rewards leave you feeling anxious, disappointed, or unsatisfied.

Willpower Exercise: When you next indulge in an insatiable desire (e.g. shopping, snacking), do it mindfully. Does the experience match your expectations? You'll probably find that you feel unsatisfied, or need much less than expected to feel satisfied.

 Use dopamine to make difficult/unpleasant tasks more appealing. When patients undergoing a 12-week therapy could participate in a small weekly lucky draw, 85% completed the therapy (compared to 20% without the lucky draw). A woman found motivation to clean up her room by using holiday music and candles to create a festive mood.

Willpower Exercise: "Dopaminize" your willpower challenge by linking it to a reward you look forward to.



Feeling Bad can Lead Us to Give Up or Give In

 Often, we seek relief or distractions when we feel bad. However, false rewards like shopping or drinking only lead to

KEY QUOTES

"We fail to recognize that the object of our desire is causing both the anticipated pleasure and the stress."

"The promise of reward doesn't guarantee happiness, but no promise of reward guarantees unhappiness."

"Desire is neither good nor bad—what matters is where we let it point us, and whether we have the wisdom to know when to follow."

"Feeling bad leads to giving in, and dropping guilt makes you stronger."

feelings of guilt and self-criticism to make things worse. Women who're worried about their finances may shop more, and dieters who're upset about their weight may binge-eat.

- We avoid thoughts of death, which terrify us. Shoppers who were asked to think about their death made longer shopping lists and were willing to spend more on comfort food. News reports of death made viewers more responsive to luxury product advertisements. Fear also leads to procrastination, e.g. we avoid seeing the doctor or writing a will.

Willpower Exercise: Notice what you do when you feel down or stressed. When you face setbacks, do you beat yourself up with guilt and self-criticism? What scares you the most?

 A willpower failure may trigger the "what-the-hell" effect coined by Polivy and Herman. Dieters, smoker or drinkers who give in to temptation may feel so bad that they end up eating, smoking or drinking even more ("what the hell, I've failed anyway"). The more they repeat the cycle, the worse they feel.

- Forgive yourself so you can stop escaping from shame/guilt and start taking responsibility and control.

Willpower Exercise: Recall a willpower failure and reframe it with self-compassion.

- Observe your inner state when you think of the failure: what words, emotions and physical sensations surface?
- Accept that all human beings lose control sometimes.
- Consider how you'd comfort a friend who's in your shoes.

 Beware of unrealistic optimism. We feel hopeful when we set an ambitious goal to change, but feel guilty and frustrated when we fail to meet those goals/expectations.

- It's better to exercise optimistic pessimism. Commit to change, then consider what may cause you to fail, and how to overcome them. Mentally prepare yourself by visualizing yourself taking action.

KEY QUOTES

"Stress points us in the wrong direction, away from our clear-headed wisdom and toward our least helpful instincts."

"We may think that guilt motivates us to correct our mistakes, but it's just one more way that feeling bad leads to giving in."

"The motivations we understand are always easier to change than the influences we cannot see."

Willpower Exercises:

- Do you resolve to change only when you feel bad? Do you take real action or are you using fantasies to feel better?
- Apply optimistic pessimism for successful change.



Soothe yourself with proven stress-relief strategies, e.g. exercise, praying, reading, music, meditation, massage, time with friends/family. These release feel-good chemicals like serotonin, GABA and oxytocin.

Willpower Exercises: Try the stress-relief strategies above.



Instant Gratification Blurs Our Long-Term Vision



We can't see the future clearly since we undervalue long-term rewards, underestimate future willpower failures, or fail to address our future needs. We give in to temptations since instant gratification appeals to our dopamine-induced reward system.

- The more immediate and vivid the reward, the more likely the primitive brain will overwhelm the prefrontal cortex. In a study, both humans and chimps were given the option to eat 2 treats instantly or wait 2 minutes for 6 treats. Both humans and chimps preferred to wait for 6 treats. Yet when the treats were placed in front of them, humans only waited 19% of the time while the chimps waited 72% of the time.
- It helps to distance yourself from the temptation, e.g. hide the chocolates at the back of the fridge.

Willpower Exercise: Before indulging, force yourself to wait for 10 min and think of your long-term goal. If you're a serious smoker, pause for 10 minutes whenever you feel the urge for a cigarette. If you're trying to overcome procrastination, only allow yourself to quit after 10 minutes.



Delay discounting means that a reward seems less valuable if we must wait for it. The higher your discount rate, the more likely you'll choose immediate rewards over future ones.

- You can improve your discount rate by weighing the current temptation against the best-possible long-term reward.

KEY QUOTES

"Optimism can make us motivated, but a dash of pessimism can help us succeed."

"Our inability to clearly see the future clearly leads us into temptation and procrastination."

"We take what we want when we want it (now), and we put off until tomorrow whatever we don't want to face today."

Willpower Exercises:

- What future rewards are you sacrificing for immediate payoffs? How much are you discounting those future rewards?
- Lower your discount rate with these steps:
 - (i) Ask: what's the best-possible long-term reward?
 - (ii) Imagine yourself enjoying the reward as if it's already yours.
 - (iii) Are you willing to sacrifice that for a fleeting temptation?

 We tend to think of our future selves like complete strangers. We imagine them to be drastically better and more capable, while their needs seem distant and unreal.

- We prioritize our present needs and make bad decisions that burden our future selves. Students committed 3x more time to tutor fellow students in future than right now. They even agreed to consume more of a nasty drink next semester (compared to drinking it now).
- Spend some time to “connect” with your future self and strengthen future-self continuity. Students who spent time interacting with their future selves (via virtual reality) were more willing to save for retirement compared those who didn't.

Willpower Exercises:

- Are you putting off important tasks for Future You to handle?
- Get to know your future self:
 - (i) Imagine the future you, making it as vivid as possible.
 - (ii) Send an email to your future self, describing what you're doing now to meet his/her goals and dreams.
 - (iii) Visualize how your ideal future self would feel, look and behave. Use that as a motivation to change.

 Pre-commit yourself so you have no choice but to move ahead:

- Create a default while you're feeling calm and objective e.g. prepay for a healthy meal plan, or forbid withdrawals from your savings account until you've reached a specific milestone.

“We put off what we need to do because we are waiting for someone else to show up who will find the change effortless.”

“The more real and vivid the future feels, the more likely you are to make a decision that your future self won't regret.”

- Make it hard to reverse your decision, e.g. don't bring your credit card when you go shopping.
- Motivate your future self with rewards or penalties. You can also get someone to hold you accountable.

Willpower Exercise: Pre-commit your future self.



Willpower is Affected by Social Influences

 Social influence affects our personal choices and self-control. Scientists Nicholas Christakis and James Fowler found that obesity spreads like an epidemic. When a friend becomes obese, it increases your future risk of obesity by 171%. The same patterns are found in drinking or smoking.

 Human brain cells contain mirror neurons to help us interpret and understand others' thoughts and feelings. If you see someone slicing her finger with a knife, you'll wince as if you were being cut. Likewise, **we "catch" others' willpower successes and failures due to 3 social responses:**

- Unintentional mimicry: we subconsciously mirror others' actions, e.g. you may unthinkingly reach for a drink when you see someone else doing so.
- Emotional contagion: we get infected by others' moods, which in turn affects how we respond to temptations.
- Goal contagion: You may decide to get an MBA or learn a new hobby after reading about someone else's experience.

Willpower Exercise: Consider the behaviors/habits you've caught from the people closest to you (and vice versa). Do others in your social network share your willpower challenge?

- The influence is bigger when you share a close relationship, like and identify with the person, or share the desire at some level. Since we hold conflicting goals in our minds (e.g. to indulge in sweets yet stay healthy), it's easy to get tipped in one direction.
- We're more likely to be infected with self-indulgence than self-control, e.g. to splurge rather than to save.

KEY QUOTES

"Both bad habits and positive change can spread from person to person like germs, and nobody is completely immune."

"Social closeness matters more than geographic closeness."

- (iii) We're also infected by what we infer from others' actions, e.g. if we see others flouting the rules, we may assume it's ok to loosen our self-control in all areas.

Willpower Exercises:

- Think of a positive role model for a willpower boost.
- At the start of each day, think about your goals and what could get in the way. You can immunize yourself against negative goal contagion just by being aware of it.



Social proof refers to our tendency to emulate others' actions, e.g. we choose the most popular dishes or watch the highest-rated movies. You're more likely to pay your taxes on time or conserve energy if you believe that everyone is doing it. Your perception matters more than what others actually think/do.

- We're motivated by our desire for approval or acceptance. So, the best way to inculcate willpower is to exert positive social pressure: (i) spread the belief that it's normal to exercise self-control and (ii) surround yourself with people who're doing the "right thing".

Willpower Exercise: If you're using "everyone is doing it" to justify an action, challenge the perception or switch to a tribe with more positive norms.

- Social shaming may be used to deter unwanted behaviors, but pride is more effective as an emotional leverage. We feel motivated to do the right thing when we believe others are watching us, so it's more effective to offer social support instead of shaming people. When participants did a weight loss program with a friend/family member, 66% completed the 10-month follow-up compared to 24% who did it alone.

Willpower Exercise: Make your willpower challenge public or enlist others to join/support you.



Denial and Suppression can Backfire



The more you try not to think about something, the more it occupies your mind—especially when you're tired or distracted.

KEY QUOTES

"Like germs that linger on a doorknob long after a sick person passed through, an action can be passed on to us when we merely see evidence that others have done."

"Willpower failures may be contagious, but you can also catch self-control."

"Social proof can strengthen self-control when we believe that doing the right thing (or the harder thing) is the norm."

"Trying to suppress thoughts, emotions, and cravings backfires and makes you more likely to think, feel, or do the thing you most want to avoid."

KEY QUOTES

"Whatever fear or desire you try to push away will become more convincing and compelling."

"If we want to save ourselves from mental suffering, we need to make peace with those thoughts, not push them away."

"Paradoxically, permission to think a thought reduces the likelihood of thinking it."

"Feel what you feel, but don't believe everything you think."

This is known as "ironic rebound". Women who tried not to think about chocolate ended up eating almost twice as many chocolates. Dieters who tried to suppress thoughts of food ended up binge-eating. The more frequently the thought returns, the more your brain assumes that it's true or important.

Willpower Exercise: What desire have you been trying to suppress or avoid? Has it worked? When you outlaw or suppress something, do you end up wanting it even more?



People suffering from anxiety disorders become more anxious when they try to suppress the negative thoughts/feelings. The best way to resolve mental suffering is to make peace with the issues.

- The best way to free yourself from bad thoughts/feelings is to stop avoiding or fighting them. In an experiment, people were coached to observe and accept their difficult thoughts and feelings, then imagine them dissolving with each breath. Brain scans showed that the intervention led participants to pay more attention to their self-critical statements yet feel less anxious.
- Let your thoughts/feelings exist without believing all of it or feeling compelled to act. In a study, students were given chocolates and told not to eat them. One group was taught to counter their urges by distracting themselves or arguing against eating the chocolates. The other group was taught to notice and accept their craving but remember that they didn't have to act on it. None of the students from the 2nd group ate their chocolates after 48 hours.

Willpower Exercise: Acknowledge your feelings, thoughts or cravings without acting on them. Notice the craving → Accept the thought or feeling (without avoiding/arguing with it) → Know you can choose not to act on it → Remember your real goal. Notice how the craving feels in your body, then imagine it passing out as you breathe.

- In yet another study, smokers were asked to go through each step of the smoking process—e.g. take out a cigarette pack, remove the cellophane, open the pack, put a cigarette in the mouth etc.—with a few minutes between each step so

they had to sit with their craving. Before the session, half the smokers were taught how to surf the urge, i.e. to imagine the craving as an ocean wave that swells in intensity then crashes and dissolves. They're to simply ride the wave as surfers. After 1 week, those who were taught to surf the turf had reduced smoking by 37% compared to the control group.

Willpower Exercise: Use this method to manage an unhelpful impulse. Imagine the sensations cresting and breaking like wave. Ride it without taking action nor pushing it away.

 **Redirect your mental energy** to find solutions for your challenges instead of trying to avoid/suppress your feelings.

- Replace the bad habit with a healthier habit.
- Redirect the time/energy, e.g. instead of watching TV, learn to cook your favorite dishes.
- Reframe a "I won't" challenge into a "I will" challenge, e.g. instead of trying not to be late, aim to be 5 minutes early.

Willpower Exercise: Focus on "I will" instead of "I won't".



Conclusion & Other Details in the Book

 Ultimately, self-control is built on 3 skills: self-awareness, self-care, and remembering your goals. The key is to be mindful of your choices instead of running on autopilot. McGonigal invites you to test each strategy and draw your own conclusions about willpower and what works for you.

 This book includes details of numerous research studies, along with examples and suggested exercises to help you apply the ideas outlined in this summary. For more details, please visit kellymcgonigal.com.

KEY QUOTES

"These three skills—self-awareness, self-care, and remembering what matters most—are the foundation for self-control."